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[00:12:11] The House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Sergeant at Arms. Okay, head page. The House is now in session. All persons not entitled to privileges of the floor, please retire to the gallery.

[00:12:29] The members will rise and be led in prayer by Reverend Justice Hill, Alfred Street Baptist Church, Alexandria, and remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance of the Flag of the United States of America, which will be led by the Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Good afternoon.

[00:12:45] Good afternoon. Let us pray. Great Creator, we thank you for this day. we thank you for this House of Delegates. We stand today asking for your blessing, that the words of our mouths and the meditations of our hearts are acceptable in your sight.

[00:13:00] We pray that in this moment in time, as we are gathered here today, that we are reminded that you are with us. I pray for each and every delegate here today to be encouraged and understanding they have been called for such a time as this. Almighty Creator, may this house serve with love, with grace and mercy.

[00:13:19] May this delegation serve with integrity and compassion, Not overly concerned with attaining power, but focused on the well-being of the people across this state and nation. We pray that walls of

injustice and oppression are knocked down, and that doors of justice and opportunity are presented to all people.

[00:13:35] I pray for the delegates today, who may feel overwhelmed and discouraged. May they be encouraged today to not grow weary in their well-doing. But as they stand today, may they not be afraid to stand for truth. May they not be afraid to stand for goodness. May they not be afraid to stand for what is right.

[00:13:52] I pray that we are reminded of the families and groups of people impacted by the decisions they make. We pray for blessings upon the state of Virginia. We pray for blessings across the United States of America, blessings across this world, and blessings upon this session. It is in your holy name we pray.

[00:14:08] Amen. Amen.

[00:14:12] The members will answer.

[00:14:49] The House will come to order. The members will answer the roll call by indicating their presence on the electronic voting board.

[00:15:10] Clerk will close the roll. Mr. Speaker, quorum is present. Pursuant to House Rule 3, I've examined and approved the general House of Delegates for January 14, 2025. Motions and resolutions under Rule 39 pursuant to the provisions of Rule 40 are now in order. Does the clerk have any announcements or communications?

[00:15:25] Not at this time, Mr. Speaker. So accordingly, in this first portion of the morning hour, pursuant to House Rule 40, speaker request to use your request to speak button for the agenda items listed up on reference on the voting board. The delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Cresick. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:15:47] I rise for an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Members of the body, today in the gallery, and I see them right up here, we have members of the Board of Veterans Services Joint Leadership Council visiting us for the day. Will you please stand? The Joint Leadership Council consists of representatives of 27 veteran service organizations, and their mission is to communicate with the governor, the General Assembly, and the Department of Veterans Services on matters of concern to the veterans community, including needed policy and legislation.

[00:16:19] I'm sure they've all been to your offices today, and I know they'll be visiting later today. With these representatives, we have the American Legion, we have Veterans of Foreign Wars, and I think we still have some other veterans groups. Please join me in thanking these patriots for their service and giving them a warm house welcome.

[00:16:36] Thank you for your service, and welcome to the Capitol.

[00:17:01] The delegate from Shenandoah, Delegate Pence. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. In the gallery today, we have several members of the Virginia Nursery Landscape Association visiting the Capitol. They are joining us from all over the Commonwealth, and they represent Virginia's garden centers, nursery growers, landscape designers, installation and maintenance contractors, greenhouses, and the green industry suppliers.

[00:17:25] Their business supports local jobs, help communities with green infrastructure, aid in stormwater management, and promote the industry's best practices. Please join me in welcoming the Virginia Nursery Landscape Association to the General Assembly. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol.

[00:17:53] The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker and members of this chamber, this morning's invocation was given by Reverend Justice Hill, who serves as assistant minister at the historic Alfred Street Baptist Church in Alexandria, Virginia.

[00:18:14] A native of Columbia, South Carolina, Reverend Hill graduated summa cum laude from St. Louis University with degrees in political science and American studies before entering his Master of Divinity, Also a Summa Kulade graduate of Duke University Divinity School.

[00:18:31] His academic foundation is distinguished by specialized certificates in preaching, Baptist studies, and black church studies, reflecting a deep preparation for his calling. He is an award-winning orator and a member of, Mr. Speaker, hear this, Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity Incorporated.

[00:18:50] Reverend Hill has been recognized nationally for his advocacy, winning both the National drum major for justice in the Belford v. Lawson National Oratorical Contest. His ministerial experience is rooted in leadership, having served as president of Duke's Black Seminarians Union and as a chaplain for Duke University's football team. Deeply committed to the intersection of faith and justice, I hope it is the pleasure of this body to give him a warm house welcome.

[00:19:20] Welcome to the Capitol, Pastor, and great job this morning. The Delegate from Rockbridge, Delegate McLaughlin. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. The delegate has the floor.

[00:19:42] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I'm honored today to recognize the Virginia Federation of Republican Women. If you're in the gallery, would you please stand? Thank you. This group was founded on the principles of limited government, individual liberty, strong communities, and they are not just people that are engaged in grassroots activities. They do voter education, principled leadership. They work really hard in our communities. They go countless volunteer hours all across our communities to make sure that our principles, our conservatism, of limited

[00:20:18] government, again, the things that are true values, that they come out. So we can't thank you enough. We're really glad that you're here today. Thank you for your activism, and I hope everyone will join me and give them a warm welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Arlington, Delegate Lopez.

[00:20:45] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Rise for an announcement. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. As chairman of the House Agriculture Chesapeakean Natural Resources Committee, I'd like to remind everybody that tonight is the annual Virginia Agribusiness Council Legislative Appreciation Banquet at Main Street Station in downtown Richmond.

[00:21:04] The event's going to begin with a reception featuring vendors of Virginia's finest products at 5.30 p.m. and then dinner begins at 7 p.m. and will be followed by a very short program. For those of you who may not know about this event, that it's always held on the first Thursday of session, and everybody should also know that agriculture is Virginia's largest private sector industry, and the banquet is historically one of the largest events of its kind during session.

[00:21:31] They're expecting around 1,200 attendees this year. Also, for all the new members, it's delicious. And so, please attend. It's really a wonderful time. And it's, like I said, it's at 5.30 tonight through around 8 o'clock.

[00:21:52] Thank you very much. The delegate from Richmond City, Delegate Cousins. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction and a motion. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, joining us in the gallery today, we have Virginians for Safer Cannabis.

[00:22:09] I ask that they please rise if they can. Virginians for Safer Cannabis is a grassroots advocacy organization bringing together parents, church leaders, community activists and concerned residents to educate the public and help legislators shape responsible and safer cannabis laws.

[00:22:30] Working with groups from across the state, they strive to ensure that cannabis policies reflect the values of safety, responsibility and community well-being for all Virginians. I want to thank them for being here today and ask everyone to join me in extending a warm House welcome.

[00:22:54] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Welcome to the Capitol. The delegate from Chesapeake, Delegate Hayes. Mr. Speaker. Oh, you had a motion. Yeah, I have a motion. Sorry. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House take up out of order H.J. 52 on page one of today's calendar.

[00:23:10] Clerk will report a resolution. House joint resolution number 52, celebrating the life of William J. Bill Martin. Mr. Speaker, I move adoption of the resolution, and I request to speak to that motion. The doctor has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. H.J. 52 celebrates the life of William J. Martin, affectionately known as Bill, who served as director of the Valentine Museum here in Richmond for over three decades.

[00:23:38] Bill was a passionate historian who helped countless individuals engage with the Commonwealth's past through his visionary leadership at the Valentine. Bill was born and raised in the Brandy Station community of Culpeper County and began to cultivate a love of history and storytelling from a very young age, spending much of his youth searching for Civil War artifacts in the area and visiting the Smithsonian Institute in Washington, D.C. with his family.

[00:24:06] Bill received a bachelor's degree in urban studies and a master's degree in public administration from Virginia Tech. Before joining the Valentine, Bill led efforts to revitalize Petersburg and later became the city's director of tourism. Bill and I bonded over our love for the city of Richmond, celebrating culture and revering a more inclusive history. Bill was himself a cultural institution and he had the style to match. He had a hand in pretty much every cultural and arts organization here in the city of Richmond with a deep commitment to elevating untold stories and holding space

[00:24:46] at the valentine to foster open public dialogue about some of the more difficult parts of richmond's and the commonwealth's history as a way of bridging divides and strengthening understanding bill's life was cut short when he died on december 28th 2025 from injuries that he sustained after he was struck by a car crossing broad street at 10th street a short walk from here and a few blocks from the valentine and probably a path that he traversed hundreds if not thousands of times here in richmond the last time i saw bill he was sitting on a bench by himself enjoying a

[00:25:26] plate of barbecue at the hog on the hill festival at libby hill park looking out over the city skyline and he told me that he had a workspace for me at the valentine sorry if i needed somewhere to hide during session.

[00:25:42] Mr. Speaker, I encourage each of us to honor Bill's legacy by approaching history with the curiosity grounded in respect and with the courage to be just a little bit uncomfortable. And I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourn in the honor and memory of my dear friend William J. Martin.

[00:26:02] Thank you. All those in favor of the adoption of the House Joint Resolution No. 52, celebrating the life of William J. Martin shall rise. The resolution is adopted. Delegate from Chesapeake,

[00:26:39] Delegate Hayes. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a motion. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I ask that on page one of today's calendar, House Resolution 8, be called up out of order, and I move the adoption of the resolution. Clerk will report a resolution. House Resolution No. 8, celebrating the life of Kenneth Mason Easley Jr. Shall the resolution be agreed to? All those in favor shall please rise. The resolution is agreed to. Delegate from

[00:27:18] Roanoke City, Delegate Rasul. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Ladies and gentlemen of the House, I'd like to introduce the Virginia Association of Career and Technical Education students and leaders, if they could please rise. With us in the Capitol are some outstanding leaders that are supporting career and technical education. They benefit not only education and the economy here in the Commonwealth. Joining us are the elected state presidents and national officers of the Virginia Career and Technical Student

[00:27:53] Organization such as DECA, FBLA, FCCLA, FFA, HOSA, SkillsUSA, TSA. I think we've got them all covered. These students are helping to develop leadership and technical expertise in a variety of services and representing over 200,000 students across Virginia.

[00:28:16] I hope it would be the pleasure of the body to give them a warm house welcome. The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring.

[00:28:35] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I ask that the clerk read a resolution, H.J. 31. The clerk will report a resolution. Mr. Speaker, members of the body, House Short Resolution No. 31, Establishing an Inaugural Committee.

[00:28:53] The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. The resolution says explanatory is the inaugural committee for Saturday's festivities. I move adoption of the resolution. Shall the resolution be agreed to?

[00:29:09] All those in favor say aye. Aye. All those opposed, no. The resolution is agreed to. The delegate from Prince William, delegatorian. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction and an announcement. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:29:24] Mr. Speaker and members of the House, it is my pleasure today to welcome in the gallery members of the Future Kings capital, members of the Future Kings. This is a remarkable group of young men visiting with us today from Northern Virginia and Fredericksburg. Future Kings is a school-based leadership and STEM program. The organization works to prepare young men from underserved communities for futures that include college, entrepreneurship, and careers in science,

[00:29:58] technology, engineering, and mathematics. Through mentorship, hands-on learning, and community engagement, they're building a pipeline of culturally responsible leaders who are already making an impact in their communities. Please join me in welcoming these young fellas to the Capitol.

[00:30:19] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Delacate for President Williams for an announcement.

[00:30:35] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, the House Appropriations staff will be presenting the introduce budget briefing today at 3 p.m. on the 12th floor in the House Appropriations Committee Room. I invite all members to join us at 3 p.m. for the budget briefing. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Pursuant to House

Rule 30, the journal shall reflect that the following members are away on pressing personal business and are granted leave from today's session. Delegates Knight, Laufer, Maldonado, and Williams. Clerk will announce the next order of business. Mr. Speaker, the second portion of the morning hour is not applicable based upon today's informational

[00:31:11] calendar. And Ms. Speaker, likewise, the third portion of the morning hour likewise is not applicable. Clerk will announce the next order of business. Fourth and final portion of the morning hour is reserved for member requests for points of personal privilege. Clerk will announce the next order of business. Clerk will call the calendar. Y'all better sell hitting these buttons faster.

[00:31:38] Y'all better pay attention to the delegate from Henrico, Delegate LaVere Bowling. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, I rise for our point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise today to speak on and celebrate this historic day, the 118th Founders Day of Alpha Kappa Alpha Sorority Incorporated.

[00:32:01] My fellow AKAs in the house know this already, but Alpha Kappa Alpha Sorority Incorporated, affectionately known as AKA, is the oldest African-American Greek-lettered sorority in the nation. And we are the first and finest, for without us, there would be no other.

[00:32:19] On January 15th, 1908, Alpha Kappa Alpha Sorority Incorporated was founded in the attic of Minor Hall on the campus of Howard University by nine courageous black women who saw the need for a support network for women with like minds who would come together for mutual uplifting and coalescence of their talents and strengths for the benefits of others.

[00:32:44] Mr. Speaker, AKA is now more than 1,105 chapters and more than 390,000 initiated members in 14 nations in all of the states. Alpha Kappa Alpha was founded with five basic tenets that I believe are worthy of the House's recognition and celebration today.

[00:33:05] One, to cultivate and encourage high scholastic and ethical standards. Two, to promote unity and friendship among college women. Three, to study and help alleviate problems concerning young girls and women in order to improve their social structure. And then four, to maintain a progressive interest in college life.

[00:33:23] And five, most importantly, to be of service to all mankind. Mr. Speaker, those nine black women, during a time where women had not yet been given the right to vote, and during the height of the Jim Crow era, saw a need for a place of acceptance, a place to advance the progress of black women by culture and by merit.

[00:33:43] to succeed in a society only three of the original nine founding members live to see the passage of the Civil Rights Act and the Voting Rights Act and it is because of the progress of Alpha Kappa Alpha sorority incorporated that I stand here today with the highest number of aka members at one time serving in this chamber with the most diverse House of Delegates in Virginia's history with the most black women to ever serve in front of the first black speaker of the house Right now, Mr. Speaker, we are not just honoring our founders, we are living their legacy.

[00:34:19] We are proof that their vision was not only bold, but enduring. And that because of their courage, black women are shaping policy, leading this house and changing the course of history. As we celebrate the founding of Alpha Kappa Alpha, I think it is important to acknowledge the legacies of those who came before us and those that are being made today.

[00:34:42] And thankfully, this chamber has not one, but now five members in the House, Delegate Price, Delegate Sewell, Delegate McClure, Delegate Cole, and myself, alongside, in that other chamber over there, the beautiful Senator Locke. So our success here, I'd say, is inevitable.

[00:35:00] Mr. Speaker, to conclude, I wish the oh-so-pretty pioneering women of Alpha Kappa Alpha Sorority Incorporated a happy Founders' Day, and may we continue to soar to greater heights of service and sisterhood thank you mr. speaker the delegate from Warren delegate Oates thank you mr. speaker I request that we go back to the first morning

[00:35:36] hour for the purpose of an introduction the delegate has a floor thank you mr. speaker today in the gallery we welcome the pro-life Virginians from across the Commonwealth who are here for their annual pro-life Lobby Day and I asked them to rise I believe they're up there throughout the morning they have been visiting our offices, wearing red, and engaging thoughtfully with members to express their opposition to the constitutional amendment before us this year that would enshrine unrestricted abortion in the Constitution of Virginia.

[00:36:11] For the fifth consecutive year, Virginians of all faiths and backgrounds have traveled to Richmond from every corner of the Commonwealth, urban and rural, coastal and mountain, united by a shared belief that every human life has inherent value and dignity.

[00:36:27] They are here because they believe that the unborn deserve a voice in these halls, and they expect their elected officials to be that voice. Please help me welcome them today to the House. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:36:51] The Delegate from Arlington, Delegate Hope. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. Delegate, ask the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Ladies and gentlemen of the House, today we are joined by Justice Ford Virginia, the Virginia Association of Criminal Defense Lawyers, and National Association of Criminal Defense Lawyers for their ninth annual Lobby Day. And so at this time, I'd ask them to please rise.

[00:37:12] Mr. Speaker, for almost a decade, these groups have been essential partners in our effort to make the Virginia's criminal legal system more fair, humane, and equitable. They've led the charge on such historic legislation as probation reform, ending mandatory jury sentencing, repealing presumptions against bail, and limiting race-based pretextual stops, often taking time away from their day-to-day jobs as public defenders to help us do this very important work in advocacy.

[00:37:39] Mr. Speaker, we thank them for their service and are thrilled to have them here in Richmond today. I ask the body to please give them a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:38:00] Clerk, we'll call the calendar. Mr. Speaker, the calendar for today, Thursday, January 15th of this second day of the 2026 session. There is no business before the body. Per House Rule 51, the House has returned to the morning hour. Does the clerk have any additional announcements or communication?

[00:38:18] Yes, sir, Mr. Speaker. Speaker sent the clerk a letter, sent me a letter regarding additional committee assignment slash changes. Accordingly, for the Committee on County, Cities, and Towns, Delegate Colson has been removed from CC&T, and Delegate Sickles has been appointed to CC&T.

[00:38:41] For the Committee on Transportation, Delegate Sickles has been removed from the Committee on Transportation, and Delegate Thomas has been appointed to that committee. For the Committee on

Health and Human Services, Delegate Singh has been removed from that committee, and Delegate Cole of Spotsylvania has been appointed to that committee.

[00:39:04] For the Committee on Communications, Technology, and Innovation, Delegate Mundin King has been removed from the committee, and Delegate Singh has been appointed to that committee. And finally, for the Committee on Privileges and Election, Delegate Cole of Spotsylvania has been removed from that committee, and Delegate Coulson has been appointed to that committee.

[00:39:23] The sheets that we update and share will be updated accordingly and will be available later this afternoon electronically and in paper version as well. Looking ahead to today is Thursday. The rest of the afternoon legislative business calendar is as follows.

[00:39:43] Committee on Labor and Commerce is going to be meeting a half hour after adjournment, approximately one o'clock or so. They'll be in House Committee Room A in the lower level of the General Assembly Building. Also a half hour after adjournment of the House Committee on General Laws, they will be meeting and they will be up on the second floor on House Committee Room B.

[00:40:04] At two o'clock, the LGBTQIA+ caucus, they are going to be meeting in House Subcommittee Room on the ninth floor. And the way that's going to work is they're going to meet whenever the latter of the House or the Senate adjourns.

[00:40:21] So they'll be meeting at some point this afternoon relatively shortly. And then, Ms. Speaker, as Chairman Torian already duly noted, the Committee on Appropriations is having a staff briefing on the House budget, a budget briefing on the budget at 3 o'clock up in the Appropriations Room on the 12th floor.

[00:40:41] Obviously, all the committees will be streamed if you want to watch that way as well. Looking ahead to tomorrow morning, which is Friday, January 16th, the Committee on Public Safety is meeting at 8 o'clock. 8 o'clock, they'll be in House Committee Room in the lower level, public safety at 8.

[00:40:58] Privileges and Elections, they're going to be meeting at 9 o'clock on the second floor, House Committee Room C. Also at 9 o'clock tomorrow, the Committee on County, Cities, and Towns, they're going to be meeting. They will be in House Committee Room B on the second floor. Then the Democratic caucus is meeting at 11 o'clock tomorrow.

[00:41:16] They will be in House Committee Room, excuse me, House Room 1 here in the Capitol. And then the Republican caucus will be meeting at 11.30 in House Room 2. So we will update all of the information I've just announced, and that's all the announcements I have, Mr. Speaker.

[00:41:34] Delegate for Richmond City, Delegate Carr. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. May we return briefly to the first morning hour just for a brief introduction? The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[00:41:51] Today, Mr. Speaker, in the gallery or making their way, we have medical students from Virginia Commonwealth University. They just left. But go ahead. Okay. Great. I'm glad they're here. Thank you. You've got great timing. So they've made their way across the road to visit the Capitol, and I would ask them to please rise to be recognized if they're still finding their seats.

[00:42:19] Mr. Speaker, the VCU School of Medicine's mission is to improve health through exceptional and innovative discovery, training, and patient care. Through the VCU Health System, the School of

Medicine is an integral part of Central Virginia's only academic medical center and the largest single provider of indigent health care in the Commonwealth.

[00:42:41] These students came today to speak with many of us as representatives of the Medical Society of Virginia to advocate for issues relating to the practice of medicine, including student loan repayment, medical down-coding, non-compete clauses, and workplace violence. While they are still in school, they seek to make an impact on our Commonwealth well before they graduate. I want the students to know that this body is committed to making Virginia the best place to practice medicine and we hope to see you here for a long time after you graduate. I would like to wish them the best of luck during their course of studies and ask that this body

[00:43:20] give them a warm house welcome. I literally just told y'all they got up and left. I saw them all in their little cute white jackets and they left. Y'all all stood up. I feel like I'm in a Money Python episode. Am I being trolled? Anyway, the delegate from Alexandria, rescue us.

[00:43:55] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourned to reconvene tomorrow at 12 noon. The delegate from Alexandria, Delegate hearing moves that when the House adjourns today, adjourn to reconvene tomorrow at 12 noon. As many in favor, the motion will say aye.

[00:44:11] Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate hearing. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House do now adjourn. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate hearing moves that the House do now adjourn. As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands adjourned until tomorrow at 12 noon.

[00:44:27] And maybe we can get those nurses back, those students back, whatever.

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